# Your case preparation checklist

Print this page. Keep it beside the case as you prepare, and bring it with your notes.

## Read with a purpose

- ☐ **Get the whole situation.** Preview the opening, ending, headings, and exhibits. Then read the case. Note who is involved, what is at stake, and why action may be needed.
- ☐ **Write the main question.** Are you choosing an action, explaining a problem, or judging a result? Write the question your analysis needs to answer.

## Analyze and make useful notes

- ☐ **Reread for evidence.** Study the passages and exhibits that answer your question, one issue at a time. Separate facts from interpretations and assumptions. Look for evidence against your first view.
- ☐ **Connect to ideas you have learned.** Where relevant, link the evidence to concepts or frameworks you already know. Explain what they help you see and where they fall short. Expect the case and class discussion to introduce new ideas too.
- ☐ **Work through the numbers.** Calculate what matters to the question. Check units, comparisons, and assumptions. Write what each result means and what it cannot establish.
- ☐ **Compare and choose.** Judge alternatives by the same criteria. Explain your main trade-off, the strongest objection, and what would change your view. For a decision, identify a first action.
- ☐ **Keep notes you can use.** Record your position, supporting evidence with page or exhibit references, key calculations, and unresolved questions. Write reasons in your own words instead of copying the case.

## Before class

- ☐ **Discuss with your teammates.** Prepare on your own first, then meet before class when collaboration is allowed. Compare reasoning and challenge assumptions. You do not need to agree on one answer.
- ☐ **Practise a short opening.** State your position, strongest evidence, and an important uncertainty. Be ready to explain your reasoning and ask a useful question. Avoid memorizing a speech.

## During and after class

- ☐ **Listen and build on others.** Answer the question being discussed. Connect your comment to what others said. Challenge ideas respectfully and revise when warranted. Take brief notes so you can keep listening.
- ☐ **Review what you learned.** After class, record what changed in your thinking and why. Note a course idea you understand better, its limits, and how you could use it in another case.

Independent handout by Kamyar Goudarzi, based on this exercise and William Ellet, The Case Study Handbook: A Student's Guide, revised edition, Harvard Business Review Press, 2018, chapters 3 and 7. Not a Harvard publication.